

THE SIEGE OF VINDANA: THE BREAKING

The King's Crusade – Module Seven

OVERVIEW

The siege turns. The party finds the weakness Vindana's defence has been hiding since Module Six, leads the assault that exploits it, and – mid-breach, with the ground fight going their way – watches it go badly all at once: Marshal Drell, out of better options, unleashes something the coalition has never seen used against it before. What happens in the sky over Vindana in the next several minutes is the reason this king will be called something else for the rest of his life. Core scenes run four to four and a half hours; this module is written to run long and should not be trimmed for time if the table is engaged – it is the campaign's centre, and it can afford to take the whole session.

TWO FIGHTS, ONE BATTLE

Run this module as two threads happening at once: the party's own ground assault, which they control directly and which should feel like a real, winnable fight with real stakes, and Xavier's airborne confrontation, which they witness rather than pilot. Do not hand Xavier's scene to the party to resolve mechanically – this is the one moment in the campaign that belongs to him, the way Module One belonged to Brenna Vane's expertise and Module Four belonged to the Ward's freedom. The party's job is to be magnificent in their own fight while his happens over their heads.

Scene	Target time	Notes
1. Finding the Weakness	45–60 min	Investigation and payoff from Module Six's threads.
2. The Breach	60–75 min	The party's own fight. DC table and stat blocks below.
3. The Dragon	20–30 min	A hazard, not a monster fight. Read carefully before running.
4. The Wyvernheart	20–30 min	Read-aloud. Do not let the party resolve this scene mechanically.
5. Vindana Falls	30–45 min	The city secured; the legend begins; hand off to Module Eight.

WHAT IS ACTUALLY HAPPENING (DM ONLY)

Drell's position was never actually unbreakable – Module Six was honest about that – and the party's own work in Scenes 1 and 2 is what breaks it. What Drell does in

response is not a plan he has held in reserve out of patience; it is the last option of a competent officer who has genuinely run out of better ones. Somewhere above Vindana, under conditions this module deliberately does not over-explain, an occupation officer with the authority to do so releases the one dragon Vale has ever bound. It is not loyal. It is compelled, the same way the wards of Elduvaine were compelled – by a rule, not by force – and it is in genuine pain the entire time it is airborne.

DM Only: Xavier is not yet the Wyvernheart when this scene begins, and every line of narration before Scene 4's marked moment must hold that line. When he takes to a wyvern – grabbing the mount of whichever Harrowmark rider is nearest, not a beast prepared in advance for him – it should read as improvised and reckless, not as a plan. He does not defeat the dragon. He recognises what it is: a captive, coerced by the same kind of rule Vale used on Elduvaine itself, and what he actually does in Scene 4 is free it, at real personal risk, rather than kill it. That choice – mercy over a kill he could plausibly have taken instead – is the actual content of the legend, not raw combat prowess. Do not let the table anticipate this; play Scenes 1 through 3 as though a straightforward fight were coming.

SCENE 1: FINDING THE WEAKNESS

Whatever the party learned in Module Six – the Ward's knowledge of a postern gate, a garrison officer's captured dispatch, or simply patient scouting since – now pays off. Vindana's defence has a real seam, and finding it precisely is this scene's job.

The postern gate is exactly where the Ward said it would be, half-hidden behind a repair to the sea wall that was never quite finished – a door built for a peacetime harbour, not a siege, and evidently forgotten by a garrison that has had three years to fortify everything it remembered to fortify.

If the Ward was rescued in Module Four and her thread was used in Module Six's Optional Content, this scene is a clean payoff – let it be found quickly and specifically. If not, run a short investigation (Investigation or Survival, DC 13) locating the same seam through ordinary reconnaissance instead; the weakness is real either way, just differently earned.

SCENE 2: THE BREACH

The party leads, or joins, a strike through the found weakness while the main siege lines press Vindana's attention elsewhere. This is a real fight, the party's own, and should feel decisive and earned.

The postern door gives on the third strike, and for a long moment nothing happens – then the alarm goes up all at once, and the fight that follows is close, loud, and entirely theirs to win.

RUNNING THE SCENE

The garrison that meets them in the breach is the legion doing its job: hobgoblin line troops falling back in order, an orc file-closer swearing at them to keep the order, and not one person on that side of the fight who believes in anything except the wage and the drill. Play it as competence under pressure, not as fury. Use the Legion blocks from the Bestiary rather than Module Three's levy-grade Occupation Guard: four to six Legionaries of the Sixth with an Optio behind them, reinforced by Marshal Drell himself (see Module Six's stat block) if the table wants a direct confrontation. This is the first time the campaign puts the Sixth in front of the party as what it actually is — Formation working, Dress the Line moving them out of a bad spot, and the whole file withdrawing in good order rather than dying in place — and the difference from every checkpoint garrison so far is the point. Per his NPC profile, Drell can be talked into surrender once his position is genuinely lost (Persuasion or Intimidation, DC 16, once he is clearly beaten) rather than killed outright — both resolutions are equally valid endings for him, and both let the module continue identically into Scene 3.

STAT BLOCKS AND SCALING

Everything the party fights in this module is already printed elsewhere: the Legionary of the Sixth, the Legion Optio and the Legion Ironshank are in the Bestiary, and Marshal Ossian Drell is in Module Six. The dragon is not a stat block by design — see Scene 3.

The breach in Scene 2 — five legionaries, an optio and Drell — is 1,650 XP across seven monsters, $\times 2.5$ for 4,125 adjusted, or $\times 2$ for 3,300 with six characters. At 6th level that is Hard for four, Medium for five and Easy-Medium for six. The set piece's Fight in the Gap — five legionaries and an ironshank — is 1,200 XP across six, $\times 2$ for 2,400 (1,800 for six): Medium for four at 6th level, and deliberately so, because the terrain is doing the rest.

TIERED SKILL DCs

Easy 10, Moderate 13, Hard 16, matching the tiers used throughout this campaign.

Task	Skill	DC	Tier
Locate Vindana's weakness without the Ward's knowledge	Investigation / Survival	13	Moderate
Force the postern door quietly	Athletics / Thieves' Tools	13	Moderate
Talk Marshal Drell into surrender once beaten	Persuasion / Intimidation	16	Hard
Keep a routing ally from panicking during Scene 3	Persuasion / Animal Handling	13	Moderate

SCENE 3: THE DRAGON

Mid-breach, with the fight turning decisively toward the coalition, everything stops mattering for a moment. Something enormous crosses the sun.

It does not roar. That is the detail that will stay with everyone who is there — it comes over the walls in near silence, wrongly quiet for something that size, and the sound that finally does come out of it, when the first coalition line breaks and scatters beneath it, is closer to a scream than anything a story would have prepared them for.

RUNNING THE SCENE

Play this as a hazard the party survives and responds to, not a monster they fight to the death. Passes overhead force a Dexterity saving throw (DC 15) or the target is knocked prone and takes 11 (2d10) bludgeoning damage from the wind of its wings alone; it does not land near the party or engage them directly — its attention, and Drell's remaining forces' attention, is on the wider battle line. The party's job here is damage control: steadying routing coalition soldiers (see Tiered Skill DCs), protecting anyone downed by a pass, and — this is the important part — noticing Xavier.

Above the chaos, unmistakably, a single wyvern climbs hard toward the thing crossing the sky, and even at this distance there is no doubt at all whose banner-colours are on its rider.

DM Only: if your table specifically wants a direct fight with the dragon instead of this hazard framing, the cleanest fix is not to write one into this module — reskin a young dragon of appropriate challenge from the SRD (checked against the party's actual level) as an alternate Scene 3, with Xavier's freeing of it in Scene 4 becoming the thing that ends that fight rather than a separate beat. This is a real departure from how the scene is designed above, and changes the module's emotional shape from witnessed legend to shared victory — make it deliberately, not by default.

SCENE 4: THE WYVERNHEART

Read this scene aloud, slowly, and do not take mechanical input from the table during it beyond what they are already doing in Scene 3's hazard below them. This is the campaign's title-earning moment, and it belongs to Xavier.

He reaches it not with a killing stroke but with both hands empty, which nobody watching from the ground understands until it is already happening — and there, at the base of one enormous, straining wing, is the thing holding the whole horror together: a mark, a binding, something small enough to miss and exactly the kind of rule Vale has always preferred to a chain. Xavier tears it free with his bare hands, at a height that should kill him for the attempt alone, and for one full second nothing in the sky over Vindana moves at all.

Then the dragon screams again — differently, this time — and the battle changes shape beneath it.

It is Ondry's sergeant, three ranks back and still bleeding from the first pass, who says it first, and it is not a title yet, not really — just a soldier saying what he saw. "Did you see that? Did anyone else see that? The king — the king just freed it. He went up there with nothing in his hands and he freed it." By evening, up and down the whole coalition line, men who were not there are already telling each other that Xavier the Wyvernheart went into the sky over Vindana and came back with a dragon at his back instead of a kill to his name. Nobody corrects them. Nobody will, for the rest of this war.

The freed dragon does not become an ally in any mechanical sense — it is not tamed, and this campaign should never suggest it has been. What it does, once freed, is leave the fight: a single pass low over the garrison's own lines, close enough to break what remains of their nerve, and then it is gone, climbing away from Vindana entirely. That alone is enough. Drell's remaining defence, already broken by Scene 2 and now watching its last desperate measure fail this completely, does not hold.

SCENE 5: VINDANA FALLS

The city's defence comes apart within the hour. This scene is aftermath, not more combat — let the party walk through a city changing hands in real time: garrison soldiers surrendering in ones and twos, Vindana's own people emerging cautiously from wherever they sheltered, and a coalition that has just watched something it will be telling stories about for the rest of its life.

Xavier finds the party before the day is out, still faintly singed, entirely unbothered by it, exactly as plain-spoken as he was at Duncarrow. "I don't entirely recommend it," he says, of the flight, and does not elaborate further, and does not yet seem to have noticed what the men behind him have started calling him.

Do not have Xavier react to the new name in this scene — per the DM-Only note above, let it exist in the ranks before it ever reaches him directly; that gap is worth preserving into Module Eight. End the session on Vindana secured and hand off directly to Module Eight, the campaign's deliberate relief-valve module after its largest set piece.

PUZZLES AND SET PIECES

Neither of these adds time. They are how the breach and the dragon are run — the first as a sequence with a decision at each transition, the second as a problem with three solutions instead of a very large hit point total.

THE PUZZLE: THE TERMS OF THE BINDING

Vale does not tame. He finds the rule that makes refusal impossible, and the dragon over Vindana is bound by an instrument rather than by a will. Everything about how it is fighting says so: it is pained, it is diminished, and it is doing the minimum the wording requires.

A party that watches it for two rounds instead of shooting at it can see the shape of the compulsion. Three observations, each a DC 14 Wisdom (Perception) or Intelligence (Arcana) check, or simply a player saying what they notice:

- **It never attacks first.** Every pass it makes follows a signal from the ground. It is not hunting. It is being told, each time, and it waits to be told.
- **The signals come from one man.** Not Vale, who is not here. An officer on the Ward Gate with a horn and a banner, relaying, and the dragon's head turns to him before every pass.
- **It obeys the words, not the intent.** Told to burn the traverse, it burns the traverse and precisely nothing else, and it flies over four exposed companies to do it.

The conclusion the party is meant to reach: the dragon must be commanded aloud, and if it cannot hear the command, the instrument has nothing to compel it with. It does not become free. It becomes idle, and lands, and waits, and that is enough.

Three ways to do it, all of them valid: silence the relay officer, which is a hard climb and a harder fight on a wall under bombardment. Silence the sound, which any caster with the silence spell can do to the Ward Gate parapet from cover. Or take the horn and banner and give the signals yourself, which requires reading them first and is worth a DC 17 Intelligence (Investigation) check and considerable nerve.

DM Only: run the puzzle and Scene Four in that order, not as alternatives. Grounding the dragon does not end the compulsion — it takes the instrument out of the sky and puts it on the ground with its head down, still bound, still in pain, still the property of whoever holds the mark. Whatever the party does here, the thing at the base of the wing is still there, and Xavier still goes up for it. A party that grounded it has made his flight survivable rather than suicidal, which is a considerable gift and should be said out loud afterwards by somebody who saw it. A party that did nothing watches him do it anyway, at odds nobody should walk away from. The title is not a reward for the party failing.

DM Only: the dragon is a hostage, not a monster, and a party that kills it has done something the campaign will not punish and will also not forget. It is a habit with teeth, the same kind of thing as the Willing Road, and it is being spent like everything else in this kingdom. If the party grounds it instead, it does not thank them, does not ally with them, and does not appear again in this module. It puts its head down in the harbour mud and stays there for two days. What the instrument actually is, where it is kept and whose office it names is the thread that runs to Module Eleven; the party can find the document in the garrison quarter afterward and should be allowed to, and it names the Keeper of the Ysolde Archive by office rather than Maedoc Vale by name.

SET PIECE: THE BREACH, IN FOUR PHASES

The campaign's largest action sequence. Run it in phases with the whole battlefield moving, and give the party a real decision at each transition rather than a corridor.

1. **The Stone Comes Down.** Nine months of Auberitz engineering resolves in about ninety seconds. Forty feet of the inner wall — Standing Light stone, six centuries old, dark now — goes over outward, and the noise arrives after the sight of it, and for a moment nobody on either side does anything at all.

"It does not crack. It leans, the way a man leans who has decided to sit down, and then the whole forty feet of it goes at once and the dust comes out sideways across the ditch faster than a horse can run. And when the dust clears there is a hole in Vindana with the sea behind it, and every single person on both sides of that ditch understands that the next four minutes decide the war."

2. **The Race.** The coalition storming party and the garrison's reserve are both running for the breach and the garrison is closer. Unless the party opened the under-wall route in Module Six, in which case they are already inside and behind the reserve, and this phase is theirs to wreck.

3. **The Fight in the Gap.** Four to six legionaries and an ironshank holding rubble against a party at 5th level. Terrain is the whole encounter: broken stone, three levels of it, and a twenty-foot drop into the ditch on the wrong side. Morale breaks when the ironshank goes down, and the Sixth withdraws in good order and takes its wounded.
4. **The Dragon.** Overhead, on the third pass, and the module's other set piece begins. See the puzzle above.

DM Only: Xavier earns the name airborne, mid-siege, in a battle that is going badly, and it must be visibly going badly first. Let the coalition lose the race for the breach. Let a company break. Then put him over the breach on the back of a Greywatch wyvern with the whole army watching, and let the name arrive from the ranks rather than from a herald. His stat block does not change. That is the point: nothing about him is different afterwards except what he is called.

NPC PROFILES

XAVIER III OF HARROWMARK, CALLED THE WYVERNHEART (AS OF THIS MODULE)

See his existing profile in Module One for baseline speech and bearing, unchanged by this module — the point of how he is written here is that nothing about his personality changes, only what people now call him. He does not perform the moment, does not narrate his own heroism, and visibly has not yet processed what he did any more than the party has.

Open thread: how Xavier himself feels about the name — earned by an act of mercy he may not think of as heroic at all — is deliberately not resolved in this module. A DM can develop this in any later scene where he and the party have a quiet moment together.

OPTIONAL CONTENT

WHAT VINDANA REMEMBERS

If the table has time after Vindana falls, let them walk the city and meet its people directly for the first time — the same drainage-and-endurance texture established in Landfall, now at the scale of a major port rather than a small coastal town. No mechanical stakes; this is pure world texture, and a chance to let Vindana feel like a real place before later modules use it as a staging ground.

DIVERGING PATHS (DM ONLY)

- **How Marshal Drell's fate was resolved.** Surrendered, killed, or fled — track which. A surrendered Drell is a genuine long-term thread (an occupation officer who chose to stop, worth more alive than as a corpse); a killed or fled Drell closes that thread but changes nothing else about this module's outcome.
- **Whether the table ran Scene 3 as written or opted into a direct dragon fight.** Record which — it changes the

emotional register of everything that follows this module, and a DM should know which version of this legend their table actually witnessed.

LOOT

- **Vindana itself.** Not loot in the ordinary sense, but the module's actual prize: a major port, secured, with everything that implies for the rest of the campaign's logistics and momentum.
- **Drell's campaign sword.** A +1 longsword of legion pattern, plain, superbly maintained, with three years of Vindana service filed into the guard as regulation notches. If Drell surrendered rather than died, he hands it over correctly and asks for a receipt, and means it.
- **A wand out of the harbour-mage's quarters.** A wand of magic missiles (SRD), taken from the rooms of an occupation battle-mage who did not stay for the ending. The first genuinely significant magical reward of the campaign, and the party has earned it.
- **The garrison's stores and armoury.** Substantial — Vindana was well-supplied for a long siege it did not get to fight. The first genuinely significant material reward of the campaign; a DM may introduce one uncommon magic item here without it feeling out of place for the first time.
- **The binding-mark.** What Xavier tore free from the dragon, if he keeps it rather than discarding it — a small, cold object that means nothing to anyone who examines it and everything to Vale, who will know exactly what its absence means. A DM's hook for a later module, not something that needs to resolve here.

THE REFRAIN

*By thought, and by word, and by deed,
the king's own chosen kept their creed.
Far from home, where the quiet land lay,
they held the line, and would not stray.*